Chapter 3 – Aryan India and the Great Vedic Debate

The Indus Valley/Harappan culture went into decline after 1900 BCE, as did the Sarasvati River. Certainly, this was not a coincidence. Other factors that have been cited as fundamental in the decay and disappearance of the people who built Harappa and Mohenjo-daro, including massive earthquakes, floods, and the lack of warfare technology. Likely for all these reasons, the people who built their world around the Sarasvati and the Indus Rivers abandoned their cities, wrote no more upon clay tablets, and faded into the background of a landscape they had once dominated. As the culture died, a new one moved in with a group of northwestern Asians: the Aryans.

The Aryans, a nomadic people, did not overtake the cities of the Sarasvati but probably moved in peacefully over the Kush mountains with their cattle, looking for somewhere their animals could graze. The newcomers to the fertile floodplains liked the lands they found on the other side of the Himalayas, and they continued farther along the Indus and Sarasvati as had the Harappan people, intermingling with the local people in their few remaining communities over the next four millennia. It was a time of monumental importance to India, both as a landmass and in terms of its identity.

The Aryan people bonded with the Sarasvati to such an extent in many places that the two cultures became one, with beliefs and traditions merging together as people started to speak the Aryan language and the Aryans adopting the agricultural practices of the Sarasvati. Though there are no written records of what exactly took place during this phase of India’s history, there is no physical evidence of a hostile takeover. It seems that the migration sparked friendly intermingling until a new culture emerged, and the cattle-herders settled in their own cities along the Indus and down along the drying riverbed of the Sarasvati.

Researchers believe that it was these Aryan people, and not the original Indus Valley inhabitants, who actually wrote the Vedic texts that would become Hinduism’s most important literature. This summation was made based on archaeological and cultural clues from the Harappan sites. If the Aryans wrote the first Vedic and therefore Hindu myths, then it was not the indigenous Indians who developed this important belief system. Perhaps a